“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 11

The Description of the Branches of the Nityānanda Trunk

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I bow to all the devotees who, like bees at the lotus feet of Nityānanda, are maddened by the honey of love, and I shall write of a few, the foremost among them.

2 Glory, glory to Mahāprabhu Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya! Whoever has taken shelter at His feet is truly blessed.

3 Glory, glory to Śrī Advaita! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory, glory to all the devotees of Mahāprabhu!

4 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is the undying tree of eternal love, and its tall trunk is the Avadhūta, Śrī Nityānanda, beautiful as the moon. I bow to His devotees, the branches of that trunk.[1]

5 Śrī Nityānanda is the mighty trunk of the tree, and on it grew branches and offshoots in great number.[2]

6 The branches grow by the water of the gardener’s will. Laden with the flowers and fruits of love, they have covered the world.[3]

7 The devotees are numberless, without end — who could count them all? For my own purification I shall name only the foremost.

8 Śrī Vīrabhadra Gosāñi is the great branch of the trunk, and the offshoots that spring from Him are beyond counting.[4]

9 Though He is the Lord, He calls Himself a great devotee; though He is beyond the dharma of the Vedas, He keeps faithfully to it.[5]

10 Within, He acts as the Lord; outwardly, He shows no pride. He is the main pillar in the hall of devotion to Śrī Caitanya.

11 Even today, through the glory of His mercy, the whole world sings of Caitanya and Nityānanda.

12 The feet of that Vīrabhadra Gosāñi are my shelter, for by His grace every desire is fulfilled.

13 Śrī Rāmadāsa and Gadādhara dāsa, devotees of Caitanya Gosāñi, stayed at Nityānanda's side.[6]

14 When Mahāprabhu told Nityānanda to go to Gauḍa, He sent these two with Him.

15 Therefore they are counted in both groups, and so it is with Mādhava and Vāsudeva Ghoṣa.[7]

16 Rāmadāsa, a chief branch, was a treasury of loving friendship. He lifted a log that it took sixteen men to carry and made a flute of it.[8]

17 Gadādhara dāsa was full of bliss in the mood of a gopī, and in his house Nityānanda revealed the *dāna-keli* pastime.[9]

18 Śrī Mādhava Ghoṣa was foremost among the kīrtana singers, and Nityānanda Prabhu would dance to his singing.

19 When Vāsudeva sang of the Lord, even wood and stone would melt to hear him.[10]

20 Wondrous were the pastimes of Murāri-caitanya dāsa: he would slap a tiger on the cheek and play with snakes.[11]

21 All of Nityānanda's associates are cowherd friends from Vraja. Each carries a horn and a staff and wears the dress of a cowherd, with a peacock feather on his head.[12]

22 Raghunātha Vaidya Upādhyāya was a great soul: the very sight of him awakened loving devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

23 Sundarānanda, a branch of Nityānanda, was His intimate servant, and with him Nityānanda enjoyed the playful pastimes of Vraja.[13]

24 Kamalākara Pippalāi was extraordinary in his ways, and his extraordinary love is known throughout the world.[14]

25 Sūryadāsa Sarakhela and his brother Kṛṣṇadāsa had firm faith in Nityānanda and were abodes of love.[15]

26 Śrī Gaurīdāsa Paṇḍita's devotion soared with prema; he had great power both to give and to receive love for Kṛṣṇa.[16]

27 Gaurīdāsa surrendered to Nityānanda his caste, his family and his place in his community, and made Śrī Caitanya and Nityānanda the Lords of his life.[17]

28 Purandara Paṇḍita was dear to Nityānanda Prabhu; he moved through the ocean of love like Mount Mandara.[18]

29 Parameśvara dāsa took shelter in Nityānanda alone; whoever remembers him attains devotion to Kṛṣṇa.[19]

30 Śrī Jagadīśa Paṇḍita purifies the whole world; like a heavy monsoon rain, he pours down the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa.[20]

31 Dhanañjaya Paṇḍita, a dear servant of Nityānanda, was utterly detached and always full of love for Kṛṣṇa.[21]

32 Maheśa Paṇḍita is a generous cowherd boy of Vraja; to the beat of the kettledrum he would dance, drunk with love.[22]

33 Puruṣottama Paṇḍita of Navadvīpa was a great soul; at the very name of Nityānanda he was seized by the great madness of love.[23]

34 Balarāma dāsa tasted the rasa of love for Kṛṣṇa, and at the name of Nityānanda he was utterly beside himself.[24]

35 Yadunātha Kavicandra was a great devotee, in whose heart Nityānanda dances.[25]

36 Kṛṣṇadāsa, an excellent brāhmaṇa born in Rāḍha, was a foremost servant of Śrī Nityānanda.

37 Kālā Kṛṣṇadāsa was a great Vaiṣṇava, among the foremost; he knew no one but the moonlike Nityānanda.[26]

38 Śrī Sadāśiva Kavirāja was a great soul, and Śrī Puruṣottama dāsa was his son.[27]

39 From his birth he was absorbed in the feet of Nityānanda, and he ceaselessly played childhood games with Kṛṣṇa.[28]

40 His son was the great soul Śrī Kānu Ṭhākura, whose body overflowed with the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa.[29]

41 Uddhāraṇa Datta, the best of great devotees, served the feet of Nityānanda in every way.[30]

42 Ācārya Vaiṣṇavānanda was rich in devotion; his former name was Raghunātha Purī.[31]

43 Viṣṇudāsa, Nandana and Gaṅgādāsa were three brothers, in whose house Ṭhākura Nitāi once stayed.[32]

44 Paramānanda Upādhyāya was a servant of Nityānanda, and Śrī Jīva Paṇḍita sang of Nityānanda's virtues.[33]

45 Paramānanda Gupta was a devotee of Kṛṣṇa, great in wisdom; Nityānanda once lived in his house.[34]

46 Nārāyaṇa, Kṛṣṇadāsa, Manohara and Devānanda — these four brothers were servants of Nitāi.

47 To Hoḍa Kṛṣṇadāsa, Nityānanda Prabhu was life itself; he knew nothing but the feet of Śrī Nityānanda.[35]

48 Among Nityānanda's devotees were also Nakaḍi, Mukunda, Sūrya, Mādhava, Śrīdhara, Rāmānanda Vasu, Jagannātha and Mahīdhara;[36]

49 Śrīmanta, Gokuladāsa, Hariharānanda, Śivāi, Nandāi and Paramānanda the Avadhūta;

50 Vasanta, Navanī Hoḍa, Gopāla, Sanātana, Viṣṇāi Hājarā, Kṛṣṇānanda and Sulocana;[37]

51 Kaṁsāri Sena, Rāmasena and Rāmacandra Kavirāja, and the three physicians — Govinda, Śrīraṅga and Mukunda;[38]

52 Pītāmbara, Mādhavācārya, Dāmodara dāsa, Śaṅkara, Mukunda, Jñānadāsa and Manohara;

53 Gopāla the dancer, Rāmabhadra, Gaurāṅgadāsa, Nṛsiṁha-caitanya and Mīnaketana Rāmadāsa.

54 Vṛndāvana dāsa, the son of Nārāyaṇī, composed the *Caitanya-maṅgala*.[39]

55 Veda-vyāsa described the pastimes of Kṛṣṇa in the *Bhāgavata*; the Vyāsa of Caitanya's pastimes is Vṛndāvana dāsa.

56 Vīrabhadra Gosāñi is the best of all the branches, and His offshoots are without end.

57 Nityānanda's devotees are endless — who could count them? I have written of some of them for my own purification.

58 All these branches are laden with the ripe fruits of love. They gave them to whomever they met and flooded all with love.[40]

59 Their love knows no bounds, nor does their striving; each of them has great power to give love and to give Kṛṣṇa Himself.

60 Thus I have told in brief of Nityānanda's devotees, whose limit even the thousand-mouthed Ananta cannot reach.

61 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: "The description of the branches of the Nityānanda trunk." *Anubhāṣya*: the eternal, imperishable tree of love is Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Himself, who bears the name Gaura; the tall trunk of that tree is Nityānanda Prabhu, the moon; His associates are the branches of that trunk. ↩
2. Heading in the edition: "By Mahāprabhu's will the branches of Nityānanda grow and become pre-eminent." ↩
3. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the gardener is Śrī Mahāprabhu. ↩
4. Heading in the edition: "The branch of Śrī Vīracandra Gosāñi." *Anubhāṣya*: Vīrabhadra was the son of Śrī Nityānanda and Vasudhā and the disciple of Jāhnavā Mātā. According to the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (67), the vyūha of Saṅkarṣaṇa who lies on the ocean of milk appeared as Vīracandra, non-different from Śrī Caitanya. ↩
5. Heading in the edition: "His glory: though Viṣṇu Himself, He acts as a Vaiṣṇava." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Vīracandra Prabhu is the vyūha of Śrī Saṅkarṣaṇa who lies on the ocean of milk; though He is the Lord Himself, He regarded Himself as a Vaiṣṇava. ↩
6. "His side" is Nityānanda's: by verse 14, Mahāprabhu sent these two to Gauḍa with Him; so too the edition's heading to verse 14: "Together with Nitāi both preach in Gauḍa." Heading in the edition: "Ṭhākura Abhirāma (the first of the twelve gopālas) and Dāsa Gadādhara." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Rāmadāsa is Abhirāma dāsa. *Anubhāṣya*: Abhirāma, whose very life was Nityānanda, is Śrīdāma of Vraja (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 126); at Nityānanda's command he became an ācārya and preacher of bhakti, and love for Kṛṣṇa awoke in anyone he struck with his whip "Jayamaṅgala". On Gadādhara dāsa see Ādi 10.53. ↩

7. Heading in the edition: “Mādhava and Vāsu Ghoṣa Ṭhākura.” *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* (on 14–15): when Mahāprabhu sent Nityānanda to Gauḍa, He gave Him Rāmadāsa and Gadādhara dāsa as companions; that is why they are named both among Mahāprabhu’s devotees and among Nityānanda’s. The same is true of Mādhava and Vāsu Ghoṣa. ↩
8. The *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (126), quoted in the *Anubhāṣya* on 11.13, speaks of a log that only thirty-two men could carry. Heading in the edition: “The pastime of Abhirāma.” ↩
9. *Dāna-keli*, “the toll pastime”: Kṛṣṇa and His friends block the gopīs’ way and demand a “toll” from them. Heading in the edition: “The wondrous deeds of Dāsa Gadādhara.” ↩
10. *Anubhāṣya* (on 15): into the collections of Vāsu Ghoṣa’s songs the *prākṛta-sahajiyās* have inserted many songs of “Gaura the lover of the women of Nadīyā” (*gaura-nāgarī*), pleasing to their senses. Vāsu Ghoṣa, who tasted the rasa of separation, never wrote such songs and never could have; the sādhaka should reject them. ↩
11. *Anubhāṣya*, quoting the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 5): oblivious of his body, Caitanya dāsa would chase tigers through the forest and ride on them, take a huge python into his lap, and stay under water for two or three days. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: he was born at Sar-Vṛndāvanapura (Bardhamān district), and on coming to Modadruma (Māmgāchi) in Navadvīpa he received the name Śārṅga Murāri-caitanya dāsa. ↩
12. Heading in the edition: “Nitāi’s associates are pure devotees, the friends of Vraja.” *Anubhāṣya*: all who took shelter of Nityānanda Prabhu belong to the sakhya-rasa of Vraja and wear the dress of cowherd boys. His consort, Īśvarī Jāhnavā Mātā, is Anaṅga-mañjarī, the younger sister of Śrīmatī Rādhikā (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 66), and the devotees who took shelter of her are also counted among Nityānanda’s associates. ↩
13. By the heading in the edition, the second of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Sudāma (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 127); the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6) calls him “an ocean of the rasa of love, the chief of Nityānanda’s companions”. ↩
14. By the heading in the edition, the third of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Mahābala (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 128); he installed the Deity of Jagannātha at Māhesh, and his descendants serve Him. ↩
15. *Anubhāṣya*: Sūryadāsa Sarakhela lived at Śāligrāma near Navadvīpa; he received the title “Sarakhela” in the service of the Muslim ruler of Gauḍa. His daughters Vasudhā and Jāhnavā are the consorts of Śrī Nityānanda (*Gaura-*

gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā 65). Kṛṣṇadāsa Sarakhela was the younger brother of Sūryadāsa and of Gaurīdāsa Paṇḍita. ↩

16. By the heading in the edition, the fourth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Subala (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 128); the brother of Sūryadāsa Sarakhela, he moved from Śāligrāma to Ambikā-Kālnā on the bank of the Gaṅgā. ↩
17. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: *pāṫi* is the common meal (*paṅkti-bhojana*), the right to sit and eat in one row with one's caste. Heading in the edition: "Gaurīdāsa Paṇḍita, whose life is Gaura and Nitāi." ↩
18. *Anubhāṣya*, quoting the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 5): at Khaḍadaha, at the home of Purandara Paṇḍita, Nityānanda danced tirelessly, and Purandara, frenzied with love, climbed a tree, roared like a lion and leapt down crying, "I am Aṅgada!" ↩
19. By the heading in the edition, the fifth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Arjuna (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 132); he accompanied Jāhnavā Mātā to the festival at Kheturi and at her command installed the Deities of Śrī Rādhā-Gopīnātha at Āṭpur. The *Vaiṣṇava-vandanā* says that he made even jackals utter the holy name. ↩
20. *Anubhāṣya*: his śrīpāṭa is Yaśaḍā near Cākdaha; at Mahāprabhu's command he preached the holy name in Nīlācala, and from there he brought a Deity of Jagannātha, whom he installed at Yaśaḍā. ↩
21. By the heading in the edition, the sixth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Vasudāma (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 127); the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6) calls him "a wonderful mahānta, in whose heart Nityānanda ever dwells". His chief śrīpāṭa is Śītalagrāma near Kāṭoyā. ↩
22. By the heading in the edition, the seventh of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Mahābāhu (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 129); he was with Nityānanda at the festival in Pāṇihāṭi and then went with Him to Saptagrāma. ↩
23. By the heading in the edition, the eighth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Stoka-kṛṣṇa (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 130); the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6) says he was "born in Navadvīpa, the intimate great servant of Nityānanda". ↩
24. *Anubhāṣya*, quoting the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6): "Balarāma dāsa, drunk with the rasa of love — even a breeze from him destroys all sins." ↩
25. *Anubhāṣya* (from the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*): Yadunātha Kavicandra was the son of Ratnagarbha Ācārya, a friend of Nityānanda's father from the same village; his brothers were Kṛṣṇānanda and Jīva (11.44, 11.50). ↩

26. By the heading in the edition, the ninth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Lavaṅga (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 132); the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6): “Kāliyā Kṛṣṇadāsa is famed in the three worlds; whoever remembers him attains Gauracandra.” His śrīpāṭa is Ākāihāṭ near Kāṭoyā. ↩
27. By the heading in the edition, Puruṣottama is the tenth of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: Sadāśiva Kavirāja was formerly, in Vraja, Candrāvalī, Kṛṣṇa’s beloved (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 156); his son is “Nāgara” Puruṣottama, the cowherd boy Dāma of Vraja (ibid., 131); Sadāśiva’s father was Kaṁsāri Sena (11.51). Rarely does one find, as in this family, four generations of perfected devotees of Gaura: Kaṁsāri Sena, Sadāśiva, Puruṣottama and Kānu Ṭhākura. ↩
28. Heading in the edition: “‘Nāgara’ Puruṣottama.” ↩
29. *Anubhāṣya*: some count Kānu Ṭhākura among the twelve gopālas. According to his family tradition, his mother left the world soon after his birth, and Nityānanda Prabhu took the infant to Khaḍadaha and named him Śiśu Kṛṣṇadāsa; in Vṛndāvana, Śrī Jīva Gosvāmī and the people of Vraja gave him the name Ṭhākura Kānāi. His śrīpāṭa is Bodhkhānā (Yaśohar district). ↩
30. By the heading in the edition, the eleventh of the twelve gopālas. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Subāhu (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 129). According to the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 5), Nityānanda stayed in his house at Saptagrāma on the bank of the Triveṇī, and through Uddhāraṇa the whole community of merchants (*vaṇiks*) was purified. ↩
31. *Anubhāṣya*: the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (97) names Raghunātha Purī among the eight Purīs who embody the eight mystic perfections (*aṇimā* and the rest). ↩
32. *Anubhāṣya*: the three brothers were brāhmaṇas of Navadvīpa; Viṣṇudāsa and Gaṅgādāsa lived for some time with Mahāprabhu in Nīlācala (Ādi 10.151). In the house of Nandana Ācārya, Mahāprabhu and Advaita once hid, and Nityānanda, on coming to Navadvīpa, stayed there for some time. ↩
33. *Anubhāṣya*: Jīva Paṇḍita was the middle son of Ratnagarbha Ācārya (11.35); in Vraja he is Indirā (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 169). ↩
34. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vraja he is Mañjumedhā (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 194, 199); he composed a garland of hymns to Kṛṣṇa. ↩
35. *Anubhāṣya*: Hoḍa Kṛṣṇadāsa is Rājā Kṛṣṇadāsa of Baḍagāchi, the son of Hari Hoḍa; at his initiative Śrī Nityānanda’s wedding took place in nearby Śāligrāma. The *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (Antya 6): “the pious Kṛṣṇadāsa of Baḍagāchi, in whose house Nityānanda showed His pastimes”. ↩
36. By the heading in the edition, Śrīdhara is the twelfth of the twelve gopālas. ↩

37. *Anubhāṣya*: Navanī Hoḍa is the son of Hoḍa Kṛṣṇadāsa (11.47); Kṛṣṇānanda is the brother of Yadunātha Kavicandra (11.35). ↩
38. *Anubhāṣya*: Kaṁsāri Sena is the father of Sadāśiva Kavirāja (11.38), in Vraja Ratnāvalī (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 194, 200). Rāmacandra Kavirāja was the son of Cirañjīva and Sunandā of Śrīkhaṇḍa, a disciple of Śrīnivāsa Ācārya and the dear friend of Narottama Ṭhākura, who prayed for his company birth after birth. Govinda Kavirāja was his younger brother, also a disciple of Śrīnivāsa Ācārya, the author of the play *Saṅgīta-mādhava* and of the *Gītāmṛta*; both received the title "Kavirāja" from Śrī Jīva Gosvāmī. ↩
39. *Caitanya-maṅgala* was the first name of the *Caitanya-bhāgavata* (see Ādi 8.33–35). *Anubhāṣya*: according to the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (109), Vṛndāvana dāsa was formerly Vedavyāsa, and Kṛṣṇa's friend Kusumāpīḍa also dwells in him. He was the son of Nārāyaṇī, the niece of Śrīvāsa, and the author of the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*. ↩
40. Heading in the edition: "By giving love for Kṛṣṇa they deliver the world." ↩